

What Time Has Taught Me About English

When I started learning English in 2018, I had no idea where this journey would take me. I was working full-time, studying at night, and I rarely had time to practice. While I was struggling with verb tenses, I often felt I would never master them. I had already given up twice before — once in 2015, and again in 2017.

But during those years of failure, something quiet was happening. Every time I tried again, I started a little further along than I had been the time before. By 2020, I was reading short articles. By 2022, I was holding basic conversations. By 2024, I had given my first presentation in English to a foreign client. I have not stopped since.

Three things have shaped my journey. First, I have stopped expecting fluency to come fast. Real fluency takes years — not months. Second, I have learned that mistakes are not enemies. They are data. Every error I have made has taught me something I had not known before. Third, I still struggle with some structures — but I no longer panic. Until I am perfect, I will keep practicing. And perfect is not the goal anyway.

If you are reading this and feeling discouraged, I want to tell you something I wish I had heard when I started. You are not behind. You are exactly where you are supposed to be. The student who has practiced English for one hour today is ahead of the student who has only thought about it. While others have been waiting for the right moment, you are using THIS moment. That is the difference.

EXERCISE — IDENTIFY THE TENSE

Read the text again silently. Underline each verb you see. Then categorize them in this table:

Tense	Examples you found
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Past Simple	
Past Continuous	
Present Perfect (Regular)	
Present Perfect (Irregular)	
Past Perfect (B2 preview)	
Future Simple	
Present Continuous	

Listening practice: your teacher will read the text aloud. Close your eyes. Notice the rhythm of each tense. The same words sound different when they are Past Simple vs Present Perfect.